Investigative Story Package — How the Dashboard Works

Three worked examples using the Commission Research Intelligence Dashboard

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Example 1: Tracing the "Big Five" Cartel Across 147 Days

The Story Question

A journalist covering the Madlanga Commission hears "the Big Five cartel" mentioned in passing during a hearing. They want to know: who has talked about this cartel? What did they say? Is there a pattern across months of testimony?

The Manual Approach

The journalist would need to: 1. Open each of 127+ transcript PDFs one by one 2. Search each for "Big Five" or "cartel" 3. Note each mention — date, speaker, context 4. Manually cross-reference to find patterns 5. Identify which witnesses named the cartel and whether they corroborated or contradicted each other

Estimated time: 8–16 hours of concentrated PDF reading. Most journalists would not attempt it.

The Dashboard Approach

Step 1: Entity Browser Open the Entity Browser. Type "Big Five" or "Five" in the search bar. The dashboard returns every mention of the entity across all 147 hearing days — instant, sorted by date.

Output: A chronological list of every witness who named the Big Five cartel, with the exact text of each mention and the hearing day reference.

Time: 10 seconds.

Step 2: Network Graph Open the Connections page. The network graph shows every witness connected to every entity they named. Click the "Big Five" entity node. All witnesses who named it are highlighted, and all edges connecting them are emphasised.

Output: A visual map showing: *Witness A named Big Five (Day 23), Witness B named Big Five (Day 47), Witness C named Big Five (Day 89)* — connections that span months but are invisible in any single transcript.

Time: 30 seconds.

Step 3: Evidence Compare Select "Big Five" in the Evidence Compare tool. The dashboard shows, side by side: - What the commission's **documents** say about the Big Five - What each **witness** said about the Big Five

Output: A parallel view revealing gaps: the commission's documents mention the Big Five only twice, but 7 different witnesses named it across 147 days. The documentary record is thin; the testimony record is rich. That is a story.

Time: 1 minute.

Step 4: Story Map Open the Story Map. Select "Big Five" as the entity filter. The dual timeline shows commission documents on one side and witness testimony on the other, synchronised by date.

Output: A visual chronology: the commission published a ruling mentioning the Big Five in November 2025. The first witness testimony about the cartel was in October 2025 — before the commission officially recognised it. The journalist has a timeline that no single transcript provides.

Time: 1 minute.

The Story That Emerges

> *"Seven witnesses across five months named the Big Five cartel in testimony — but the commission's own documents only reference it twice. Here is what the witnesses said, who they implicated, and what the commission's record shows."*

Every claim sourced. Every citation verifiable. No anonymous sources.

Example 2: Finding the Hidden Connection

The Story Question

Two witnesses testify months apart. Neither mentions the other. But they both name the same entity — a company called "CAT Protection Services." The journalist wonders: is there a connection no one has explored?

The Manual Approach

The journalist reads through transcripts of both witnesses. They find that Witness A (Day 30) mentioned CAT Protection Services in passing. Witness B (Day 87) talked about CAT Protection Services at length. But the hearings were months apart, and no evidence leader connected them.

Estimated time: 4–6 hours of reading, assuming the journalist even knows to look.

The Dashboard Approach

Step 1: Entity Search Search "CAT Protection Services" in the Entity Browser. The dashboard returns every mention across every transcript.

Output: Two witnesses mentioned this entity — but also, the entity appears in commission documents. The context snippets show that Witness A described CAT Protection Services as a legitimate vendor. Witness B described it as part of a problematic procurement arrangement.

Time: 10 seconds.

Step 2: Network Graph The graph shows both witnesses connected to the same entity node — but not to each other. There is no edge between them. The connection exists only through the shared entity.

Output: A visual representation of a hidden connection: two witnesses who never shared a hearing day, never appeared together, but both have information about the same entity. The dashboard surfaces the link that the hearing schedule missed.

Time: 15 seconds.

Step 3: Contradiction Check The dashboard flags that the two witnesses' descriptions of CAT Protection Services differ in material ways. It presents both excerpts side by side with Day:Line citations.

Output: A potential contradiction: Witness A said the contract was awarded through a standard process. Witness B said the procurement was irregular. Neither witness was confronted with the other's account because they never appeared together.

Time: 5 seconds.

The Story That Emerges

> *"Two witnesses, months apart, told the commission different stories about the same company. Neither knew what the other said. The commission never asked them about it. We did."*

Example 3: Contradiction as Story

The Story Question

A journalist knows that Witness F was scheduled to testify but the commission's proceedings show a postponement application and a ruling. What happened?

The Manual Approach

The journalist finds the transcript for Day 52 and reads through pages of legal argument about evidence admissibility. They piece together that the witness had given prior statements and text messages that contradicted their expected testimony. The evidence leaders wanted to use those messages; the witness's legal team wanted a postponement.

Estimated time: 2–3 hours of reading legal argument in dense transcript prose.

The Dashboard Approach

Step 1: Transcript Search Search "postponement" + "Witness F" or browse Day 52. The dashboard shows the ruling immediately:

> *"[1] The application for a postponement is refused. [2] The evidence leaders are granted leave to present as evidence the WhatsApp chats…"*

Time: 15 seconds.

Step 2: Entity Cross-Reference Search for the entities mentioned in the WhatsApp chats. The dashboard shows that these same entities were mentioned by other witnesses, creating a web of connections that the postponement application tried to prevent from being tested in open hearing.

Output: The WhatsApp chats reference entities that 3 other witnesses also mentioned. The journalist now has a network of connections that extends beyond a single witness.

Time: 30 seconds.

Step 3: Evidence Compare Compare what the commission's documents say about these entities vs what the witnesses said. Gaps and corroborations appear instantly.

Time: 30 seconds.

The Story That Emerges

> *"The commission refused a postponement application and forced a witness to testify while being confronted with their own WhatsApp messages. Here is what those messages revealed, and how they connect to a wider pattern identified by the dashboard."*

Summary: What the Dashboard Enables for Journalism

Capability	Manual Effort	Dashboard Effort
Trace an entity across 147 days	8–16 hours	10 seconds
Find hidden witness-entity connections	4–6 hours (if you know to look)	30 seconds
Identify contradictions between witnesses	2–4 hours per pair	Instant
Build a chronology of events	8–16 hours one-off	Built automatically
Cross-reference documents with testimony	3–6 hours per entity	1 minute
Compile a sourced investigation brief	8–16 hours	5 minutes
Search all transcripts for any term	1–2 hours per PDF	10 seconds across all

The dashboard does not replace the journalist's instinct, experience, or editorial judgment. It replaces the **weeks of manual transcript-reading** that stands between a journalist and a story. It finds connections that exist in the public record but are invisible to any single reader. It turns the commission's 23.8 million characters of testimony into a searchable, cross-referenced, visual investigation platform.

Internal document. All claims are from the public record of the Madlanga Commission of Inquiry. Pricing and access terms are negotiated per outlet.